

169

Philemon and Onesimus

A master and his slave, both brought to Christ through Paul, and a letter asking one to welcome the other.

Paul's shortest letter is a personal appeal about two men. Philemon was a believer, probably in Colossae, who hosted a church in his home. Onesimus was his slave, who had left him and possibly wronged him. Somehow Onesimus came to Paul in prison, became a believer, and was a real help to Paul. Paul sent him back asking Philemon to receive him "not now as a servant, but above a servant, a brother beloved," and offered to pay whatever he owed. We are not told how Philemon responded. The gospel reaches into the most unequal relationships and calls for reconciliation.

At a glance

Names	Philemon; Onesimus, "useful" or "profitable"
Philemon	A "fellowlabourer" whose house hosted a church (Philemon 1–2)
Onesimus	Philemon's slave, who had left him (Philemon 15–16)
Home	Probably Colossae, in Phrygia (Colossians 4:9, 17)
When	c. AD 60–62, in a Paul imprisonment (place debated)
Key people	Paul, Timothy, Apphia, Archippus, Tychicus
Main passages	Philemon; Colossians 4:7–9
Later mention	"A faithful and beloved brother" (Colossians 4:9)

"Not now as a servant, but above a servant, a brother beloved."

Philemon 16, KJV

The life of Philemon and Onesimus

Dates are approximate (AD). Most place the letter during Paul's imprisonment in Rome, c. AD 60–62. Some prefer an earlier imprisonment at Ephesus or the one in Caesarea.

Earlier Probably Colossae	● Philemon believes Philemon comes to faith, apparently through Paul, who reminds him that he owes Paul "even thine own self." A church meets in his house. <i>Philemon 1-2, 19</i>
Before the letter	● Onesimus leaves Onesimus, Philemon's slave, is parted from his master. Paul hints that he may have wronged Philemon or owed him something. <i>Philemon 15-16, 18</i>
c. AD 60–62 With Paul in prison	● Onesimus believes Onesimus comes to Paul and becomes a believer. Paul calls him "my son Onesimus, whom I have begotten in my bonds." He becomes dear and useful to Paul. <i>Philemon 10-13</i>
c. AD 60–62 Sent home	● Carrying a letter Paul sends Onesimus back with Tychicus and calls him "a faithful and beloved brother, who is one of you." <i>Colossians 4:7-9; Philemon 12</i>
On arrival	● Philemon's choice Philemon must decide how to receive him. Paul is confident he will do "more than I say," and asks him to prepare a room for Paul's hoped-for visit. <i>Philemon 17-22</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Christians have read this letter in different ways. Paul does not directly command Philemon to free Onesimus, though some read "thou wilt also do more than I say" (verse 21) as a hint. Both sides of later debates over slavery appealed to it.

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- 1 Philemon refreshed the saints.** His love and faith encouraged believers: "the bowels of the saints are refreshed by thee, brother." *Philemon 4-7*
 - 2 Philemon opened his home.** The church met in his house. *Philemon 2*
 - 3 Onesimus came to faith.** In Paul's prison he became Paul's spiritual son. *Philemon 10*
 - 4 Onesimus served Paul.** Once "unprofitable," he was now "profitable," a play on his name, and Paul wanted to keep him. *Philemon 11-13*
 - 5 Onesimus went back.** He returned to the master he had left, carrying Paul's letter. *Philemon 12; Colossians 4:9*
 - 6 Paul appealed instead of commanding.** "Yet for love's sake I rather beseech thee." *Philemon 8-9*
 - 7 Paul asked for a brother's welcome.** "If thou count me therefore a partner, receive him as myself." *Philemon 17*
 - 8 Paul offered to pay.** "If he hath wronged thee, or oweth thee ought, put that on mine account." *Philemon 18-19*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; neither man is named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: Deuteronomy 23:15-16	Do not hand an escaped slave back
Echo: Genesis 44:32-34	Judah offers himself in Benjamin's place
Echo: Genesis 50:19-21	Joseph forgives the brothers who wronged him

New Testament

Philemon 1-25	Paul's appeal for Onesimus
Colossians 4:7-9	Onesimus travels with Tychicus
Colossians 4:17; Philemon 2	Archippus named in both letters
Echo: Luke 15:20-24	The father runs to welcome his son
Tradition	A bishop Onesimus of Ephesus (Ignatius, c. AD 110); same man unproven

For discussion

- Observe:* What does Paul offer to do for Onesimus (Philemon 17-19)?
- Understand:* How would "a brother beloved" (Philemon 16) change how Philemon saw him?
- Apply:* Is there someone you need to welcome back or be reconciled with?
- Apply:* Where could you stand in the gap for someone who has fallen short?